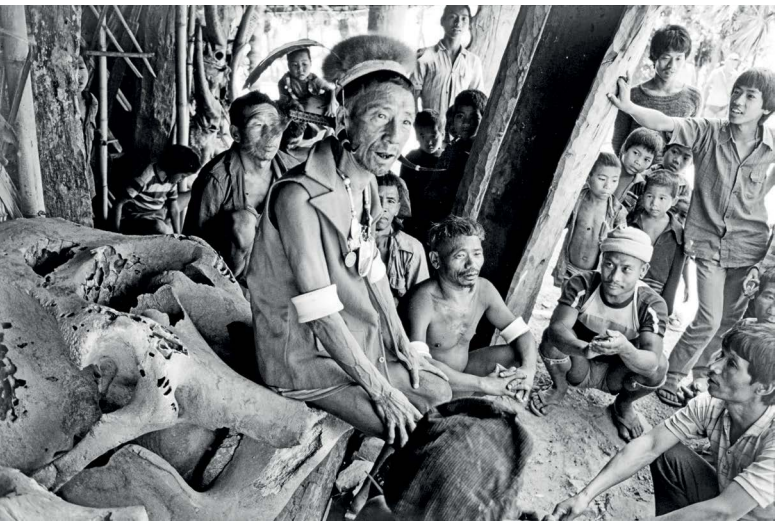
ADITYA ARYA







CUSTOM KITS (From right clockwise) Wife of the deputy Ang (chief) of Mon village, Konyak Nagas; Somra Nagas wearing their Loin head dress; Wangkau, the Great Ang of Chui, spiritual head of the Konyak, holds court seated on an elephant-skull throne; Untitled



PABLO BARTHOLOMEW

PHOTOGRAPHY

Time with the Tribes

An exhibition in Gurugram by photographers **Aditya Arya** and **Pablo Bartholomew** is a striking reminder of the rich traditions of the Nagas

"When I travelled to Nagaland in the 1980s, it was a critical time in its history. Much has changed today," says photographer Aditya Arya, whose exhibition *The Nagas* with fellow lensman Pablo Bartholomew documents the lost traditions and lifestyle of the tribes there.

The 132 images shown at Museo Camera Centre for the Photographic Arts in Gurugram attempt to present a distinction between the old and new lifestyles, reinforcing the significance of visual anthropology for future generations. The grey walls of the gallery have evocative black-and-white shots taken by Arya, the most striking of which are the headhunters Nagaland was once known for. There are several other stories, capturing the dying traditions of the state's dominant communities—from how they dressed to what they feasted on, and more.

"Thanks to the Festival of India, I got an opportunity to venture into the state as early as 1984. I kept going back for six years. There were several challenges, from accessibility to shooting on film. I had to take the assistance of the army to reach the interiors," recalls Arya, who was inspired by books and accounts of early travellers and anthropologists like Christoph von Fürer-Haimendorf. Meanwhile, Bartholomew's journey to Nagaland is interlinked with the stories of the Naga tribes that his father, art critic and photographer Richard Bartholomew, encountered while fleeing Japanese forces in Burma (present-day Myanmar) to India.

THE NAGAS is on till Sept. 15 at the Galerie at Museo at the Museo Camera Centre for the Photographic Arts, Gurugram, Haryana

Bartholomew embarked on a decades-long exploration of the Naga tribes, from 1989 to 2009, across many states in the Northeast, including Assam, Nagaland and Arunachal Pradesh. Despite the dangers of a lingering insurgency, he traversed the region in his rugged Gypsy, which doubled as a portable photo studio.

At Museo, Bartholomew's photographs pop up on a backdrop of bright yellow. Some images are imbued with contemporary touches, showcasing music and dance, costumes and jewellery, and sculptures, among other themes. "When I travelled to Nagaland in the early 1980s, everything was untouched. Pablo went a few years later, things had changed a little by then," says Arya.

The breakthrough was a long process, Arya admits. It took time to build trust in the locals, and for them to open up. "I would stay with them and eat in their houses. We also took help from the *dobashis*, who knew both Assamese and Nagamese, and were employed by the government," says Arya. ■

–Geetika Sachdev